



Card Jitsu

A Board/Card Game Analysis by Naomi Kendall

The Basics

Game Name: Card Jitsu

Genre: Children's Game, Trading Card Game, Strategy, Head-to-Head

Theme: Cartoon Fantasy, Karate Ninja Penguins, Rock-Paper-Scissors Battle

Tone: Casual Fun

Gender: Any/All

Age: Children (Aged 5+)



Overview

Card Jitsu can be described simply, as a more advanced version of the classic schoolyard game- 'Rock, Paper Scissors'

The version of Card Jitsu I will be analyzing here, is the physical adaption derived from the success of the online version of the game on Club Penguin; a popular flash MMO game released in 2005 that has since shut down.



Main Objective (Win/Lose Conditions)

The player's main objective is to try and win each round and try to meet the winning criteria, to win the game.

Each time a player wins a round, they display their winning card in front of them, and continue to keep them there until a full match has been won by either player.

The amount of rounds played continues to increase and the match will not end until either player meet the win condition.

The player can **win** the game by:

1. *Displaying three cards of the same element icon but different colours.*
2. *Displaying three cards of different element icons (fire, water, snow) and different colours.*

The player can **lose** the game by:

1. *Not meeting the winning criteria before the opponent*



Core Gameplay

Card Jitsu is a two-player (Head-to-Head style) card game that at its core, can be described as a more advanced version of the classic schoolyard game 'Rock, Paper Scissors', except instead, it is replaced with three elements- Water, Fire, Snow).

In this game:

Water Beats Fire

Fire Beats Snow

Snow Beats Water



The cards of the game contain one of each of these attributes:

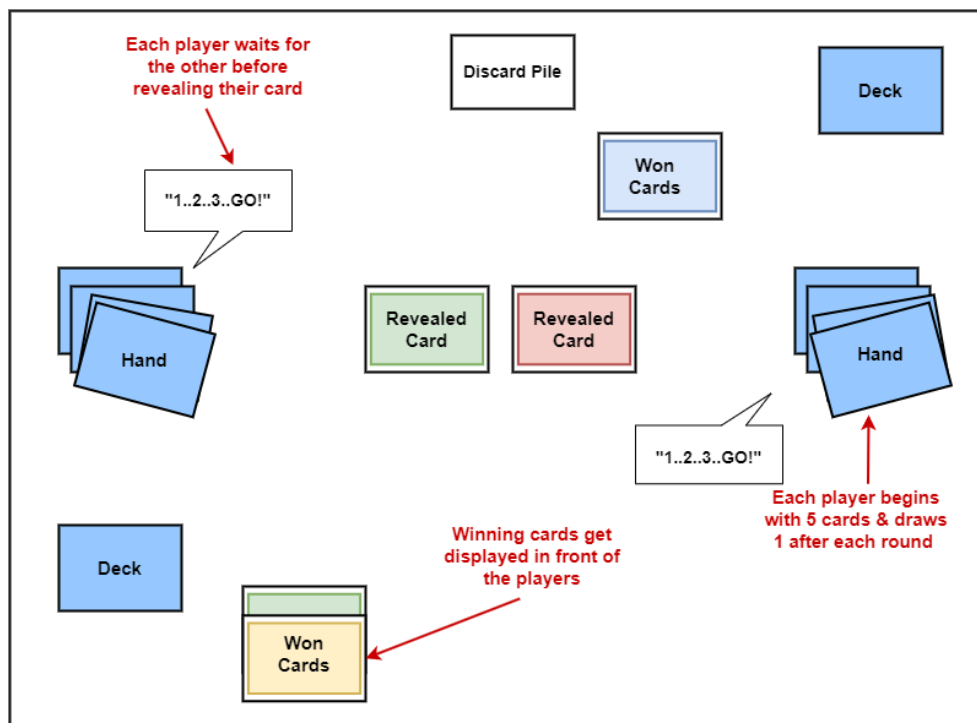
- ❖ A Element (Fire, Water or Snow)
- ❖ A Number (Ranging from 2 to 12)
- ❖ A Colour (Red, Blue, Yellow, Purple, Green)



Elements & Colour go towards the win condition of the game, while the Numbers *only* serve as a way to deal with tiebreakers. Colours exist only to differentiate cards of the same element from each other, and do not impact the gameplay until the end of the rounds, when the winning card is stashed in front of the player.

When each player reveals their card to judge and compare, they must first look at which of the card's *elements* wins. In the case of the same element, the *highest number* wins. Else, the round ends in a draw. Each Player can have as many of these cards in their deck as they like (as long as they can shuffle it), but their hand can only consist of 5 cards at a time.

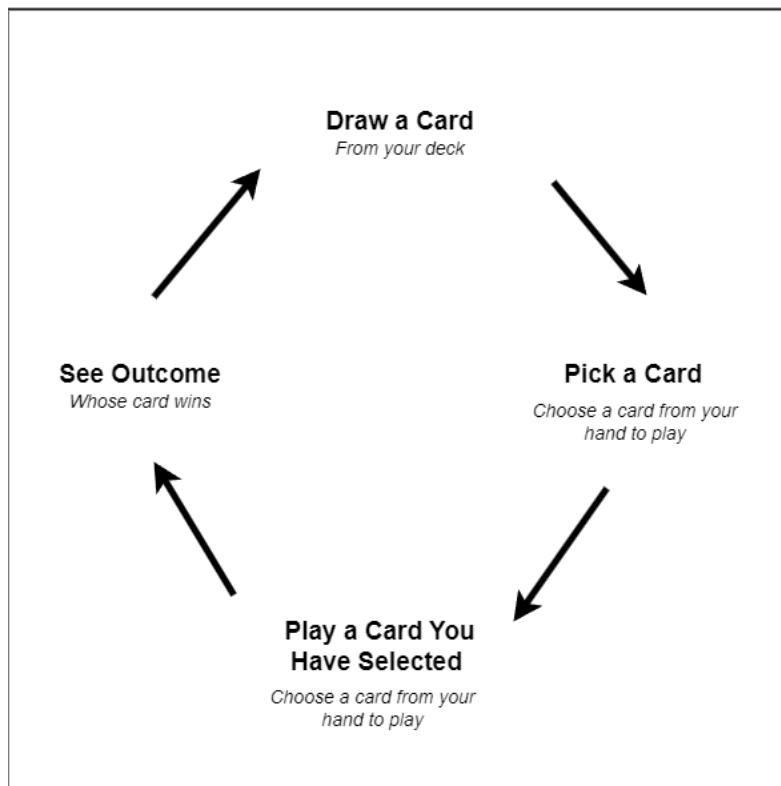
Setup



The round begins with both players drawing 5 cards from their decks. These cards become their hand. They then pick one of those cards in their hand to play, revealing their chosen card at the same time as the opponent. The outcome of those two revealed cards, determines who wins the round. The winning player displays their winning card in front of them, and the losing player discards their card into the discard pile. Both players redraw a new card from their deck, and the game continues to the next round until a player wins the game.

Core Gameplay Loop

Draw a card → Pick a card from your hand → Play a card (once both you and opponent are ready at the same time) → See Outcome → REPEAT



Cognitive Gameplay

What strategies and processes must the player adopt to play and win the game?

The player must adopt what's described in-game as a 'think like a ninja' mindset, needing to think ahead, attempting to predict and read the other player's movements, (what card they're going to play next based on current gameplay state, what the other player must be thinking) to try to stay one step ahead.

The players also must become more self aware and observant of both their own body language, and their opponents as to try to not reveal any information about.

The game achieves this, by revealing only little bits of information to the players, each time a round is played.



Social Gameplay

How do the players interact with each other?

The players interact with each other when they reveal their chosen cards at the same time, communicating to each other when they are ready to reveal it, and discussing the outcome of those revealed cards. They also interact

If there is a digital version, how does social interaction differ?

The social interaction of the digital Card Jitsu card game differs in that you can not interact with your opponent during the match in any way, only outside of it. You only see the cards they play.



Emotional Gameplay

What emotions/reactions does this game invoke in players?

Card Jitsu invokes a great sense of suspense, while the players are in the process of revealing cards to each other. Up until the opponent's card is revealed, the player will not know for certain what card they've chosen to play, and can only make an educated guess based on the gamestate, and what they've observed. Until the card is revealed, the player is left on-edge on whether they played their cards right or not.

Winning the game invokes feelings of achievement and victory, due to needing to win in such a specific way.

Demographic

The core demographic and target audience of the physical version of Card Jitsu is children aged 5+. The game is very simple and easy to pick up, but will most likely not be very entertaining or challenging to older players.

The type of player who plays Card Jitsu, are mostly fans of the online virtual world, Club Penguin looking to get their virtual Card Jitsu cards in real life for their collection, and looking for a simple pastime they can play with friends.

The gender of players playing Card Jitsu is quite diverse, and the game caters to both boys and girls (and others) by creating cards that contain various different types of artwork, which are both cool and cute.